villagers and after crossing Se-la the force reached Tawang on 30 April 1932.

At first the Monpa were evasive and not willing to engage with the British officers. However, the men managed to make inroads with the local population that lived in a state of constant terror, exploited by both the lamas from the Tawang Monastery and the dzongpens. The next two months were spent in visiting various scattered settlements, the officers impressing on the people that they were British-Indian citizens who could not be subjugated by the Tibetans. The resentment against years of exploitation soon began to manifest itself and the Monpas began to grow more forthcoming.

On his return to Assam, Captain Lightfoot reported that the inhabitants in both the Sherdukpen and Monpa areas were most willing to come under British administration but they lived in mortal dread of Lhasa and its henchmen. The Sherdukpens, in fact, referred to the Tibetan dzongpens as zakpas, meaning ‘the plunderers’. Lightfoot recommended that gradual steps be taken to bring the area under British-India’s administration. While the Assam government in Shillong concurred with Lightfoot’s recommendations, the Indian government dragged its feet, citing financial constraints. This inaction had its ramifications in the Dirang-Tawang belt, for those who were perceived to have been friendly with the Assam Rifles personnel were subsequently victimized by both Tibetan dzongpens and monastery lamas.

While the Tibetan government strongly protested Captain Lightfoot’s expedition, the Chinese stepped up their cartographic offensive. Maps published around that time showed Tawang as a part of Sikang Province and the Tibetan government continued to collect taxes south of the McMahon Line once the Assam Rifles party withdrew. The British-Indian government, ever hypersensitive to Chinese reactions, ignored the issue.

THE 1940S (THE TIBETANS COME CALLING)

Far more dramatic events then took centre stage. The thirteenth Dalai Lama, Thubten Gyatso, died on 17 December 1933 and the long process to find and anoint a successor began. This period coincided with the outbreak of World War II and, suddenly, in the geopolitical scenario, China found itself on the side of Great Britain and the United States of America. The Americans, far removed from the ground realities of Sino-Tibetan relations,